

STARTING MONDAY

The first time I met her, I was ten minutes late.

"You're late."

"Yeah, was—"

"I don't need to hear it. Sit down."

Her office was small. Beige. Stacked with files and a dying pot plant on the windowsill. Photo of a golden retriever on her desk.

Everything about the room said: *I care very much about rules and also dogs.*

She flipped open my file and started reading.

Not skimming. Reading.

"High risk of reoffending."

I said nothing.

Her finger moved further down the page.

"Multiple breaches of bail conditions."

"Yeah."

Another page.

Then another.

She stopped.

"How many times have you actually been arrested?"

I thought about it.

"Honestly?"

She looked up.

"I've lost count."

That was the first time she properly looked at me instead of the file.

Not shocked. Not judgemental.

Just trying to work out what the fuck she was supposed to do with me.

She closed the folder.

"You're not working?"

"No."

"You need a job."

I didn't say anything.

The truth was, I wasn't looking for one.

I didn't need a job to make money. Money had never really been the problem. I knew how to make money. I'd been doing that long before she ever opened my file.

She just didn't know how.

And I certainly wasn't going to explain it to my parole officer.

"You need structure," she said. "Somewhere you have to be every day. Somewhere people know whether you turn up or not."

That was different.

She wasn't really trying to fix the money.

She was trying to fix what I did with my time.

She picked up the phone. Dialed. I sat there while she spoke to someone on the other end.

"Hi, yes, I'm calling about your courses. What's starting in the next week?"

Long pause. Scribbling on a notepad.

"Commercial cookery? Level two? When does that start?"

Another pause.

"Perfect. I'm enrolling someone. I'll send the paperwork today."

She hung up.

"You're starting a cooking course on Monday."

"What?"

"Commercial cookery. Level two. Polytech. Every day, nine to five. Miss a day, I'll breach you, and you'll go back to finish your sentence. Understand?"

I stared at her.

"I don't want to be a fucking cook."

"I don't care what you want."

Not meanly. Just factually.

"You need structure, supervision, and a skillset."

Then she looked straight at me.

"You're starting Monday. Nine a.m. Questions?"

Yeah.

Quite a few, actually.

Most of them probably weren't going to help my situation.

She wasn't much older than me. Maybe around my age. And she'd just sat there and told me exactly what I was going to do, where I was going to be, and what time I was going to fucking be there.

That didn't sit well with me.

At all.

But there was a difference between not liking something and being stupid enough to say so.

She had the ability to send me straight back to prison.

I knew it.

She knew I knew it.

So I gave her the answer that kept everybody happy.

"Nah. All fucken good."

* * *

Monday morning, I was up at 0630.

Didn't need an alarm. Prison had taken care of that.

Stace watched me get dressed in the clothes Mum had bought the day before: black pants, a collared polo and polished black steel-caps, laced twelve-up.

All black.

I'd shaved my head and trimmed the goatee. Was looking sharp in the new threads.

Or felt it, anyway.

Stace didn't seem worried. I'd already made my position clear on Sarah, the course and my promising new career in commercial cookery.

Her position was simpler.

Go.

Sarah hadn't left much room for interpretation. Miss the course, breach parole. Breach parole, go back and finish my sentence.

So, yeah.

I was going.

Didn't mean I had to be fucking happy about it.

I went out to the shed and ripped a few cones. Maybe more than a few.

I was nervous. Properly nervous.

Not about cooking. I still didn't give a shit about cooking. It was the classroom that got me. Walking into a room full of people I didn't know. left school at thirteen.

Now, however many years later, I was ten minutes away from sitting in one again.

Fucken fabulous.

I rolled a smoke, grabbed the BMX and headed off.

It wasn't far, but finding the classroom took longer than it should have. I sparked up as I rolled in. The place looked fucking dead, and for a minute I wondered if I had the right building.

Figured I was early.

I dropped the BMX outside and left it there. Didn't lock it. That genuinely didn't occur to me.

Who the fuck was going to steal my bike?

That was how my head worked back then.

The cones hadn't done much for the nerves. I stood outside, finished my smoke, then went in.

No point standing there all day.

There were already about twenty people in the room. So much for being early.

Some looked like they'd only just left school. Others were older. Most had already found someone to talk to.

I hadn't.

Didn't know a fucking soul.

I stood there, trying to work out where I was supposed to go. A few people noticed me, then a few more. The conversations didn't stop, but the room got quiet enough for me to notice.

Didn't exactly help.

Eventually, everyone went back to whatever they'd been talking about. That was when I spotted the guy obviously running the show.

Glen.

I walked over and put my hand out.

Shook his hand.

Something I've always done that. Walk into a room, introduce yourself, shake hands. Didn't matter who you were dealing with.

It was just respect.

"Take a seat wherever you like."

I headed for the back and found a seat on my own.

That suited me fine.

Glen got everyone settled and started going through the course: what we'd be doing, how it worked and what was expected.

Theory, practical, theory test, practical test.

Rinse & Repeat.

Pretty straightforward.

I listened.

A couple of the younger guys didn't. They talked amongst themselves. Nothing major, but they kept at it.

I looked over a couple of times.

One of them noticed. They quietened down, then started again.

Glen was halfway through explaining something when I heard them laughing.

I'd had enough.

"Oi. Show some fucken respect."

That shut them up.

Actually, it shut everyone up.

For about two seconds.

Then one of the little cunts laughed.

I looked straight at him.

"Something funny, mate?"

His face changed.

He knew.

"Want to step outside with me?"

The kid didn't answer.

Didn't really need to.

Glen did.

"I appreciate the sentiment, but that's not how we handle things in a classroom."

He didn't make a big deal of it. Didn't raise his voice.

Just redirected me.

I wasn't trying to undermine him. Quite the opposite. As far as I was concerned, they were disrespecting him and I'd dealt with it.

Apparently threatening to take someone outside wasn't how Glen would've dealt with it.

Fair enough.

I nodded and sat back down.

That was it.

No lecture. No carrying on. Glen went straight back to what he'd been teaching and, unsurprisingly, everyone else shut the fuck up and listened.

When we broke a while later, everyone started heading outside.

The kid I'd challenged stayed in the classroom.

Can't imagine why.

* * *

The first few days were mostly theory.

Food safety. Hygiene. Basic terminology. How the course worked. The sort of shit you need to know before anyone lets twenty people loose in a training kitchen with knives and gas burners.

Then came the uniforms.

Chef jacket.

Check pants.

Apron.

Neckerchief.

And the hat.

I looked at the fucking thing.

There was absolutely no chance I was wearing that.

I'd already accepted being ordered into a cooking course by my parole officer. I'd turned up every morning. Sat in the classroom. Kept my mouth mostly shut.

There had to be a limit somewhere.

Apparently the limit was a chef's hat.

Everyone else started getting changed.

I didn't.

Glen noticed.

Of course he fucking noticed.

"You need to be in full uniform for practical."

"I'm not wearing that."

I pointed at the hat.

Glen looked at it.

Then at me.

"Yes, you are."

There wasn't any attitude in it.

Which was becoming slightly inconvenient.

"I look like a fucken clown."

A couple of people laughed.

Glen didn't.

"Everybody wears the same uniform."

That was difficult to argue with.

Especially when Glen was standing there in his.

Black pants, white chef's jacket with black buttons and the traditional tall chef's hat.

When he was walking around the kitchen, the hat was on. When he was teaching from the front, he'd take it off and sit it on the bench beside him.

But he wore the uniform.

So did everyone else.

Which left me rapidly running out of reasons why I shouldn't.

Didn't mean I liked the fucking thing.

But I put it on.

All of it.

Then I walked into the kitchen.

* * *

The first practical wasn't anything remarkable.

Nobody handed me a knife and discovered some hidden fucking talent. There was no moment where I suddenly realised this was what I was supposed to do with my life.

I was there because Sarah had put me there.

That hadn't changed.

But I kept turning up.

Theory days. Practical days. Tests.

Nine o'clock every morning.

At first, that was enough.